



ALL-AFRICA STUDENTS UNION
UNION PANAFRAICAINE DES ETUDIANTS
الاتحاد جميع الطلاب الأفريقي
Defending students rights since 1972



PAN-AFRICANISM & AFRICAN CULTURE
WORKING GROUP

STUDENT REFUGEE PROJECT



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BACKGROUND

More than 79.5 million people were displaced by the end of the year 2019, amounting to 1% of the world's population.

Specifically, 26 million people have been displaced, of whom nearly half were young children¹.

A large percentage of these children have lived in prolonged or constant displacement.



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48% of children aged between 12 and 17 are of school going age are out of school.

77% gross enrolment of refugees at the primary level is at the same for both 2019 and 2020

38-43% of the 79.5 million internally displaced people are children under the age of 18

According to the data, a significant 48% of children aged between 12 and 17 and are of school-going age are out of school. The 2019 gross enrolment of refugees at the primary level is the same as that of 2020, about 77 %. Although the rate of displaced students at the secondary school level has more than doubled since 2014, this constitutes only 31% compared to previous years, highlighting the disparity between primary and secondary enrolment. This disparity is apparent for girls. Data shows that 36% of refugee boys enrolled in secondary education as opposed to only 27% of refugee girls.

The proportion of refugee students in postsecondary education is only about 3% ². Sub-Saharan Africa is home to more than 26% of the world's refugees. In recent years, partly due to ongoing crises in the Central African Republic (CAR), Nigeria, and South Sudan, the Continent's refugee situation has contributed to these numbers. The outbreak of new conflicts in Burundi has also contributed to the rise in these numbers .

The lack of educational opportunities in refugee camps is one of the most significant challenges to social and economic development. As time passes, the need for qualified teachers and educational resources increases. However, it is challenging for refugees to have access to quality education. This challenge creates a feeling of being cut off from educational opportunities as they wait for an opening that never arrives. Enrolling refugees in schools is an excellent way to fit them into community life.

Having quality education for refugees is critical to their ability to participate in life after they have arrived in the country; the SDG goal reiterates the need to make education inclusive for all. Additionally, education can provide coping mechanisms and encourage stability following conflict and displacement . Looking around the world, it can be safely said that the more significant proportion of refugees are children and youth; children under the age of 18 make up an estimated 30–34 million (38–43%) of the 79.5 million internally displaced people as of the end of 2019. Youth leadership could be vital in getting refugees admitted into schools. The All-Africa Student Union deems it necessary to embark on the Education for Refugee Students Project (E4RSP) to provide refugees' educational opportunities and promote their integration into local communities.

GENERAL OBJECTIVE

The project's overall aim is to create a strong youth movement that brings together governments, intergovernmental organizations, civil society groups, and non-profit organizations to aid refugee children's access to education.

Specific Objectives

- To build student leaders' capacity to be more responsive to refugee students' inclusion in mainstream education.
- To reshape the conversation surrounding refugees/displaced migrants.
- To encourage students to take action to demand access to education for refugee students.

Expected Results:

- Student leaders to establish mechanisms to facilitate access to education for refugee/displaced students in their respective countries.
- Increase public support for refugee students.

WHY THE NEED

Young refugees are particularly vulnerable among the refugee population. They are at a greater risk of being wasted because they are prevented from accessing education due to their internment in camps. In the past, refugees have received their education in parallel systems to the country of origin's systems. Refugee education has historically been thought of as one in camps with the premise that refugees will return home quickly⁶. Unlike their peers (non-refugees), they cannot realize their dreams; they do not have enough education and training to attain meaningful employment. Highly educated refugees can become productive citizens of both the host and home country by their creative and innovative capabilities and their ability to start businesses and organizations or work as Doctors, Engineers, etc. A school and formal education, in general, is a reliable way to make the world more peaceful and prosperous. Education for Refugee Students Project (E4RSP) is a project dedicated to ensuring that refugees have increased access to education within established educational structures.

MAIN ACTIVITIES

- Capacity Building Workshops for student leaders.
- Advocacy campaigns centred on awareness-raising activities that focus on access to education for refugees.
- Round table discussions with Ministers of Education to ensure the streamlining of educational systems to accommodate refugees.

PROJECT BENEFICIARIES

The project's primary beneficiaries will be young refugees (both boys and girls) who live in the five countries the project will be rolled out. The student leaders will also benefit from the project.

PROJECT SUSTAINABILITY

The project can be sustained through Student leaders' empowerment who would lead the advocacy campaign by ensuring an understanding and recognition of their contribution to society.

MONITORING AND EVALUATION

AASU has a functioning internal Monitoring and Evaluation Team led by a competent officer with significant experience managing projects in Africa. The M & M&E Team works closely with the Internal Audit Team to provide critical reviews and assessments of all AASU projects. Additionally, AASU operates under the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration of Ghana and is subject to the Government of Ghana's independent external audits.

We shall employ these tools to conduct the evaluation:

- Social Return on Investment (SROI)
- Basic Efficiency Resource Analysis (BER analysis)
- The monitoring and evaluation will be done periodically (preferably monthly).
Key indicators will include the campaigns. The project will be evaluated through the collection of data on statistics of the enrolment of refugees.

ABOUT REQUESTING ORGANIZATION

The All-Africa Students Union (AASU) is the most significant student movement in Africa and a very dominant force on the Continent and beyond. AASU organizes all students in Africa – from the basic level to Institutions of higher learning; in essence, the Union is the umbrella organization for all students of Africa.

Since its inception in 1972, AASU now has presence in 54 Countries in Africa. The Union played an important role in the struggle against colonialism and the ending of apartheid in South Africa. Today, AASU is at the forefront of the fights for equal access to quality education, quality assurance in higher education, harmonization of higher education systems – with key emphasis on the mobility of academics and comparability of qualifications, democratic governance, defending students' rights, promotion of gender and African culture, sustainable development, entrepreneurship, fostering of academic freedom, freedom of research and autonomy of higher institutions of learning, and the promotion of peace and democratic values, and other noteworthy objectives.

In the year 2000, the UN awarded AASU a certificate of merit in recognition of the Union's efforts at advancing students' rights and championing the democratization of education across the African Continent.

See: <http://www.un.org/press/en/2000/20000410.dev2241.doc.html>

The Union is wholly student-run and student-led, autonomous, representative, and operates according to democratic principles. The executives of the Union are democratically elected and representative of all the sub-regions across the Continent.

The All-Africa Students Union's key strength lies in its diversity and numerical strength (*representing tens and millions of African Students*), which it leverages as a bargaining tool to advocate for the supreme interests of students. The Union is made up of diverse students, regardless of their religion, gender, cultural background, political persuasion, ethnic origin, or social standing. The Union achieves its core mandate through:

- **Advocacy** – The Union campaigns actively in defence of students' rights, and the passage of policies on the need for the democratization of education across the Continent, with emphasis on access, equity and equality.
- **Capacity Development** – The Union facilitates education and training to build the capacities of students through conferences, seminars, training programs and educational materials to enhance the potential of graduates to access decent jobs, develop their leadership skills and significantly improve their skill sets.
- **Networking** – The Union creates the platform and environment for networking amongst members aimed at building closer relations for healthy partnerships.
- **Partnerships** – The Union constantly seeks out collaborative partnerships with like-minded organizations to work together to advance progressive agendas.

The 7 Strategic Priorities of the Union are:

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| 1. Education and Students Right | 5. Pan-Africanism and African Culture |
| 2. Gender Advocacy | 6. Migration and Mobility |
| 3. Capacity Building | 7. Democracy and Good Governance |
| 4. Environment and Climate Action | |

WHY PARTNERSHIP WITH AASU IS STRATEGIC

AASU already has the grassroots mobilizing capacity, our membership cuts across student groups on the Continent at the national and regional levels. Our alumni rise fast to hold political and business leadership positions in their various countries. As the pinnacle of students' leadership across the Continent, AASU serves as the body of energetic and intellectual young leaders of the Continent, the very reason this constituent is very strategic to drive social change and shape public opinion. As an intellectual community, our discourses and campaigns have shaped Africa's past and will certainly mold the future. Our membership daily drives the agenda at national levels and shapes public opinion, it is therefore critical that we engage to achieve our shared objectives.

Critical to our success is the fact that our membership comprises most students and young people in Africa and the diaspora. Our vast numbers give the Union power and strength to represent the views of students of Africa.

This accounts for why the Union is considered the first choice for consultation and partnership on issues affecting Africa's students and young people.

RELATIONSHIP WITH AFRICAN UNION

AASU has a working relationship with the African Union Commission (AUC) Education Division. In the recent past, we have been involved as the student voice in two (2) key initiatives of the African Union in partnership with the European Union to harmonize Africa's education ecosystem.

REFERENCES

- ¹ <https://www.unhcr.org/blogs/inclusive-education-refugees/>
- ² <https://www.unhcr.org/afr/education.html>
- ³ [https://www.unhcr.org/africa.html#:~:text=Sub%2DSaharan%20Africa%20hosts%20more,\)%2C%20Nigeria%20and%20South%20Sudan.](https://www.unhcr.org/africa.html#:~:text=Sub%2DSaharan%20Africa%20hosts%20more,)%2C%20Nigeria%20and%20South%20Sudan.)
- ⁴ <https://blogs.worldbank.org/education/every-refugee-child-deserves-quality-education>
- ⁵ <https://www.unhcr.org/refugee-statistics/>
- ⁶ <https://blogs.worldbank.org/education/every-refugee-child-deserves-quality-education>